went bad, we were able to overcome those challenges.

Interviewer: How adventurous was your trip?

Vartika Joshi: When we were crossing the Tasman Sea, we witnessed the brilliant Southern Lights from sea. It was rare to watch that in those months, that too from sea. We were absolutely awestruck as we were not expecting it, to see the entire sky lit up in green light. There was bio-luminescence, dolphins swimming in the wake of the boat like our neighbours and a variety of sea creatures. We spotted a dead sperm whale once and we thought it was an island from a distance, it was so huge. We are not specialists, so whenever we spotted something in the sea, we had to Google it to learn more about the species.

Interviewer: How did your crew spend time deep in the sea?

Swathi P: During circumnavigation, we picked up some hobbies and kept posting pictures of delicacies like golgappas and cakes. We also read books when the weather was pleasant and did some quilling and craft work. While team leader Joshi read comics and the Ramayana during her journey, I loved cooking as well so I indulged in baking. I also liked crafting a lot, so I used to make lampshades. I love it when people appreciate the food that I cook, so I gave my crew members the best dishes that was possible on land with the limited resources that we had on the boat.

Vartika Joshi: Six is a great number, we were always entertained. We watched movies, listened to music, and you won't believe some of the goodies the crew rustled up in our tiny pantry, even while sailing in rough seas. We made parathas, baked cakes and breads, and even made halwa and rasgullas!

We celebrated festivals at sea. When we think about it now on land, we remember the Diwali we spent at sea. We celebrated three birthdays including the first birthday of the boat; also specific occasions like crossing the equator, the International Date Line and such.

Interviewer: What motivated you to fulfil the country's expectations?

Swathi P: We knew that the entire country was watching us and praying for us, so we never wanted them to have a single day thinking that we are in trouble. We knew that it is going to happen but the people out there did not know what kind of challenges we were facing. So, one of the motives that we kept in mind was that we did not want to frighten them. We decided that once the circumnavigating was over, we are going to show what we have actually gone through.

Interviewer: As a woman, how would you consider this expedition?

Vartika Joshi: It is a matter of great honour and we couldn't have imagined anything better for our cast-off. Of course we being an all-woman team, it is a great boost to women in the country. But, as we are going as sailors, and we as sailors have seen that the sea does not discriminate between genders. It is always gender-neutral and we have realised that gender does not play a role in sailing. But to boost the morale in the country and for more

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